

platforms at 64 billion in 2012 and that number is projected to hit 268 billion by 2017. Roughly 91% of this sales figure is attributed to free applications and paid applications being the other 9%. This trend too is going to stay on the same path for a couple of years down the line.

Back in the day, carriers had a walled garden approach strictly controlling the app content worldwide, and in countries like India the developer revenue share was as low as 30%. Apple came in with the App Store and in one fell swoop changed the game for everyone, developers et al. This was followed by Google's Android Market and Nokia's Ovi Store. Today we have various platforms present in the market that run on mobile phones, tablets, and even netbooks; viz Adobe AIR, Java ME, Meego, Symbian, Android, iOS (Apple), Samsung bada, RIM (BlackBerry), Windows Mobile, Brew and many more. In the last few years, the balance has changed sharply in favour of a select few with Android being the most popular platform and IOS coming in at a close second.

The app industry is one of the most rapidly evolving technology fronts right now. Devices such as mobile phones, tablets and now even home appliances are running apps. Apps that can be downloaded, apps that can connect to the internet and apps that can define lifestyles are all in operation. This process has been ongoing for quite some time. A few years ago when we spoke to Siddharth Sharma from RapidSoft Technologies, an Indian app development company which caters to telecom clients such as AT&T, Telefonica and Verizon, the company was actively building such solutions.

Development landscape demystified

The entire developer ecosystem can broadly be categorised into the demand side and the supply side. On the demand side, you have three kinds of entities. There are the gaming, publishing and content companies trying to develop their own offerings in the mobile space. This kind of content could even be in the cloud since you have a web interface on mobiles as well. Then, there are people who are developing their own applications and porting those applications on to the different marketplaces. The third kind includes OPDs or Offshore Product Development companies that exploit the arbitrage opportunity that's created in this space. On the supply side, there are again three profiles for mobile developers – MIS developers, who are part of a large enterprise organisation whose concerns are compatibility, scalability, security etc; game developers, who work across platforms; and